

The Great DIFF

With the resurgent periphery playing a defining role in shaping the national destiny, India has become a true federation of states in which various identities and aspirations have found their legitimate place

■ By Prabhu Chawla

As a political journalist, I have been a regular at Parliament sessions for the past 30 years. I had entered its holy precincts first as a student and then as a teacher. The building in light red stone, the most evocative edifice of Indian democracy, has a radius of almost a kilometre. During the early '70s and the '80s, the doors of all the big rooms in its outer circle bore the name plates of Congress

ministers, including India's first prime minister Jawaharlal Nehru. Recently, on a round of the building, I found prime space occupied by people who have nothing to do with the Congress—leaders like Lalu Prasad Yadav, Ram Vilas Paswan, Sharad Pawar, A. Raja, Anbumani Ramadoss and Raghuvansh Prasad Singh. This tells the story of how the tectonic plates have shifted in politics.

